

States **BIHAR**

| By Amitabh Srivastava |

For Sunil Kumar, 46, two decades of toiling hard, with only sand and cement as company, had almost made his life dull and uneventful. Then, something happened: Singapore. The trip was a state-sponsored holiday for the executive engineer employed with the Bihar Rajya Pul Nirman Nigam Limited (BRPNNL) for his good performance in completing the Kataunjha bridge that connects Muzaffarpur and Sitamarhi. This overseas travel incentive was not just for completing a bridge, but executing a project that had been pending for over 17 years. As part of the corporation's unique performance-based reward programme to motivate its employees to deliver, six employees have been rewarded with overseas travel till date with Kumar being the lucky one to be chosen twice for his exemplary work. Also, the corporation has given a cash reward of Rs 20,000 each to 11 of its engineers.

Till some years ago, these lucrative performance-based incentives were unthinkable in the state Government-owned corporation which had a problem paying salaries to its employees. The state's engineering arm was in serious financial trouble, facing a deficit of Rs 17 crore with the possibility of closure looming large. The inspiring turnaround story of the loss-incurring department, however, began in April 2006 when Pratyaya Amrit, a 1991-batch IAS officer, was tasked to resurrect the corporation.

The corporation, which was established on June 11, 1975, with much fanfare and many promises, had turned comatose within a decade. By 2005, it had metamorphosed into one telling specimen of all that was wrong with Bihar. With over 500 corporation employees who were grappling with irregular salaries, unbundling appeared the only option for BRPNNL. The countable loss was Rs 17 crore but the intangible one was bigger—a huge loss of face. The corporation had been running heavy losses for almost a decade because of the reasons that once plagued many government or-

Bridging the GAP

Performance-based incentives help loss-making BRPNNL finish pending projects and post profits



BRPNNL CHAIRMAN PRATYAYA AMRIT AND EMPLOYEES OF THE CORPORATION IN ITS NEWLY BUILT GYMNASIUM (RIGHT)

ganisations across the country—too much of non-plan expenditure, budget constraints, poor commercial profitability, fewer projects to handle, tardy execution, over-dependence of non-existent bailout packages, besides, of course, a Bihar-specific endemic reason like the unfavourable business environment.

At the onset, BRPNNL had to first solve these issues that it had inherited, even as a strategy was being redefined for the challenges ahead. The old con-

stants and the assumptions were the biggest de-motivators. On top of it, there was hardly any hands-on experience to handle big projects. Indeed, it was a tight situation and not everybody thought Amrit would succeed in his endeavour, leave alone make BRPNNL a profit-making venture. But things changed and for good. Thanks to his untiring attitude, the corporation that was once heading towards bankruptcy posted a profit of Rs 83.80 crore in the last fiscal. As part of its social responsibility, it also contributed Rs 25 crore to the Chief Minister's Relief Fund. It is also the highest tax paying state